

that has a gamut of features. It has a well-maintained site and a very active development and release schedule. It has a surprisingly large number of downloads from India. There is another SIS that goes by the unpretentious name of Centre (miller-group.net). But do try out its demo site because the software functionality and customer support seems anything but unpretentious.

The Kuali Foundation (kuali.org) has the Kuali Financial System (KFS), an open source financial package for institutions of higher learning. They are also working on a student system. KFS has commercial support available from established names.

Koha is a popular Integrated Library System (ILS) that is being used by many libraries in the world including the Delhi Public Library. It is immensely scalable, making it amenable for use even by smaller school libraries.

Learning management

The primary purpose of a school is to promote and facilitate learning. The world of FOSS offers quite a few applications that help host learning material, making it accessible to the students in a controlled environment, and then facilitating the evaluation of students on what they have learned.

Moodle is a celebrated course management system (CMS), or learning management system (LMS), with a large community and almost a fan following. It is feature rich, allowing you to host your own lesson material and evaluation tests organised by virtual classrooms.



Figure 2: Moodle courses



Figure 3: Caroline demo



Figure 4: Allutor demo page

Caroline (caroline.net) is a compact course management system with some basic exercise types available for students. It is well suited for light duty applications such as online orientation for new employees.

Sakai (sakaiproject.org/portal) is a collaboration and courseware management platform. It is enterprise class with support for up to 200,000 users. It is claimed to be written by educators for educators. Check out the *References* section to learn how Stanford University is using Sakai.

ATutor can be counted with the best amongst the learning management systems, built with accessibility and adaptability in mind. With a rich feature list that takes some time to absorb and a list of useful modules for expandability, ATutor is a must-have on your evaluation short list.

LRN (dotlrn.org) is an enterprise class software solution to support e-learning and to build digital communities. Most FOSS enterprise class solutions come with a committed and active community of stakeholders whom you can interact with for help, feedback, or plain *gyan*. LRN, too, is backed by a community of stakeholders.

ILIAS (ilias.de) is an LMS with German origins and has a very distinguished cooperation network or advisory board. Spend some time on the website and you'll immediately realise how complete and well documented it is, besides marvelling at the lengths the developers have gone to make it accessible and usable. There is a detailed client list, including some case studies. The latest stable release is barely a couple of months old. Is it a candidate for your evaluation short list? You bet.

As an aside, you may not appreciate the value of a community until you realise that most closed-source commercial/proprietary products are completely managed by product management teams of a finite size. These teams may not necessarily have the user community as their primary driver due to corporate compulsions. (We have heard that before, haven't we?). In contrast, community-driven products, with the greater wisdom that goes into them, evolve more solidly, and not necessarily any slower. The evolution of GNU/Linux